SORT 1 / 96

GUEST BEDROOM

Guest Bed and Linens

Take every sheet set that has been demoted to this room and try each fitted sheet on the actual mattress. If a corner pops off while you are making the bed, it is a rag, not a spare. Fold each pillow in half and let go, and anything that stays folded goes out.

STRAIGHTEN 2 / 96

GUEST BEDROOM

Guest Bed and Linens

Nest each complete set inside one of its own pillowcases so a full change of bedding is a single grab from the shelf, and keep the spare set for this mattress size in this room rather than back in the family linen cupboard.

SHINE 3 / 96

GUEST BEDROOM

Guest Bed and Linens

Vacuum the mattress surface and the seams with the upholstery tool, turn the mattress end to end, and wipe the top edge of the headboard, where dust settles unseen because nobody sits up in this bed.

SAFETY 4 / 96

GUEST BEDROOM

Guest Bed and Linens

Walk from the pillow to the door with the lights off, the way a guest will in the small hours in a room they do not know, and clear anything their shin will find. If the bed sits under a blind, tie the cord up out of reach of a visiting toddler.

STANDARDIZE 5 / 96

GUEST BEDROOM

Guest Bed and Linens

Write on a tag tucked into each bundle: bed size, one fitted, one flat, two cases, one blanket. A standard is the best way you know today, written down.

SUSTAIN 6 / 96

GUEST BEDROOM

Guest Bed and Linens

Strip and wash the bed the day the guest leaves, not the day before the next one arrives, so the room sits ready rather than pending. One wash, by whoever waved them off. The check is the doorway: a made bed with a second set folded on the shelf is ready, and a bare mattress is a job left for a night you will be short of time ...

SORT 7 / 96

GUEST BEDROOM

Guest Nightstand

Open the drawer and take out what has been hiding in a room nobody uses: dead batteries, a clock radio that lost its time when the power blipped, three paperbacks nobody chose, cough drops fused into their tin. None of it belongs to a guest, and none of it belongs to you either.

STRAIGHTEN 8 / 96

GUEST BEDROOM

Guest Nightstand

Set the lamp on the side a right hand reaches first from the pillow, run the charger head over the top edge of the nightstand so it hangs where a hand lands, and stand the tissue box upright rather than laying it in the drawer.

SHINE 9 / 96

GUEST BEDROOM

Guest Nightstand

Wipe the lamp base and the inner rim of the shade, vacuum the drawer out rather than wiping it, and clean the water ring the last guest left because they could not find the coaster.

SAFETY

10 / 96

GUEST BEDROOM

Guest Nightstand

The water glass, the lamp cord and the outlet all meet in one square foot here, so run the cord behind the nightstand rather than across the top, and keep the glass on the far side from the lamp. Take your own medication out of this drawer entirely, because a visiting child opens drawers before anything else.

STANDARDIZE

11 / 96

GUEST BEDROOM

Guest Nightstand

Tape a small card inside the drawer with the wifi name and password, where the bathroom is, and which way the shower faucet turns. Write it out even for guests you know well, because the whole point is that nobody has to knock on your door at midnight to ask. The card stays in that drawer permanently, and the password is the ...

SUSTAIN

12 / 96

GUEST BEDROOM

Guest Nightstand

The night before an arrival, switch the lamp on and plug your own phone into each cable while you make the bed, so a dead bulb or a failed cable is found by you rather than by them at two in the morning. Two minutes, host's job. Slip shows when you open the drawer and find something of the household's in it, because a drawer ...

SORT

13 / 96

GUEST BEDROOM

Guest Dresser

This is where the household's undecided things hide behind a closed front: off-season sweaters, a bin of cables, wrapping paper and ribbon, a bag of outgrown baby clothes waiting on a decision about a second child. The sweaters go to your own wardrobe, the cables to the drawer that already holds cables, and the baby clothes get ...

STRAIGHTEN

14 / 96

GUEST BEDROOM

Guest Dresser

Put the empty drawers at the top, where a guest opens first and bends least, and the spare linens underneath, since you fetch those twice a year and they fetch socks twice a day.

SHINE

15 / 96

GUEST BEDROOM

Guest Dresser

Vacuum inside each drawer and wipe the runners, then leave the empty drawers open with the window cracked while you finish the rest of the room. Old wood holds a smell, and a guest's clothes take it on in one night.

SAFETY

16 / 96

GUEST BEDROOM

Guest Dresser

A dresser with two empty top drawers is lighter at the top than it looks, and a visiting child will climb it. Strap it into a stud, and pull each drawer fully out to check that it stops rather than sliding free onto a foot.

STANDARDIZE

17 / 96

GUEST BEDROOM

Guest Dresser

Write on a label inside each empty drawer's front edge: reserved, guest. It stops the household reading a visibly empty drawer as an invitation, which is what happens to every empty drawer in an occupied house. Label the lower drawers by contents as well, spare linens for this bed, so nobody has to open all four to work out ...

SUSTAIN

18 / 96

GUEST BEDROOM

Guest Dresser

During your own seasonal wardrobe change you open these two drawers in the same trip and confirm they are still empty before the swap counts as done. Thirty seconds inside a job already happening, by whoever is doing the swapping. Slip is exactly one thing: something of the household's in a drawer labeled reserved. Recovery is ...

SORT 19 / 96

GUEST BEDROOM

Guest Closet

Take everything out and put it on the bed. This closet is where the house keeps holiday decorations, a wedding dress in a zipped bag, a box of old phones, and paperwork from two addresses ago. Sort by whether a named person will use it in a named situation, and route the rest out.

STRAIGHTEN 20 / 96

GUEST BEDROOM

Guest Closet

Give the guest the end of the rod nearest the door and nearest the light, put the household bins at the far end, and use matching hangers throughout so the empty six read as an offer rather than as leftovers.

SHINE 21 / 96

GUEST BEDROOM

Guest Closet

Wipe the rod with a damp cloth, because a rod nobody touches grows a fuzz that transfers straight onto a dark shoulder, then vacuum the floor corners where dust gathers undisturbed for months.

SAFETY 22 / 96

GUEST BEDROOM

Guest Closet

Anything stored above the rod sits over the head of whoever is reaching for a hanger. Move heavy boxes down to floor level and keep only light, lidded, labeled bins on the top shelf, with nothing stacked so the top item overhangs the edge.

STANDARDIZE 23 / 96

GUEST BEDROOM

Guest Closet

Mark the guest boundary physically with a strip of tape on the rod or a hanger stop, so the line is visible from the doorway and does not depend on anyone remembering it.

SUSTAIN 24 / 96

GUEST BEDROOM

Guest Closet

Every time you take a seasonal bin down from this closet you check the taped line and count the empty hangers before shutting the door, which costs the length of standing up. Six matching hangers past the tape is the number, so five is the signal and you read it without moving anything. Recovery is walking the stray garment ...

SORT 25 / 96

GUEST BEDROOM

Guest Welcome and Work Surface

Clear the surface completely. It will be holding gift wrap, an ironing pile that never made it back, a printer that has not been switched on this year, and paperwork someone brought in here to deal with in peace. The ironing goes back to the wardrobe it came from, the printer either earns a desk somewhere it gets used or leaves ...

STRAIGHTEN 26 / 96

GUEST BEDROOM

Guest Welcome and Work Surface

Put the welcome bin where a guest sees it the moment they stand in the doorway, and set the luggage rack where a suitcase can open fully without hitting the bed frame or the closet door.

SHINE 27 / 96

GUEST BEDROOM

Guest Welcome and Work Surface

Wipe the desk and the chair seat and back, both of which collect a dust film in an unused room, and check the desk lamp works now rather than during a guest's first evening.

SAFETY

28 / 96

GUEST BEDROOM

Guest Welcome and Work Surface

The classic hazard here is the extension lead run across the floor because the only outlet is behind the bed. Move the desk to the outlet rather than the outlet to the desk, and if a suitcase must live on a folding rack, open it and lean on it to be sure it holds a packed case without folding.

STANDARDIZE

29 / 96

GUEST BEDROOM

Guest Welcome and Work Surface

Photograph the room in its ready state and keep the print inside the lid of the welcome bin, so setting up is matching a picture rather than remembering a list.

SUSTAIN

30 / 96

GUEST BEDROOM

Guest Welcome and Work Surface

When you carry the departing guest's sheets to the wash, the welcome bin comes with you and gets restocked on the way back. Host's job, five minutes. The ready-state photo inside the lid is the check, so slip is a comparison rather than a memory: whatever is in the photo and not in the bin is what you are missing. Recovery is ...

SORT

31 / 96

GUEST BATHROOM

Guest Vanity Counter

Take everything off the counter and put back only what a visitor would use: soap, tissues, hand towel. The travel conditioner, the spare contact lens case, and the razor that ended up here because the main bathroom ran out of room all go back where they belong or into the trash.

STRAIGHTEN

32 / 96

GUEST BATHROOM

Guest Vanity Counter

Set the soap on the side your hand reaches without crossing over the basin, tissues at the back corner clear of splash, and the hand towel on a ring or hook visible from the door. A guest should never have to open a cabinet to find a towel.

SHINE

33 / 96

GUEST BATHROOM

Guest Vanity Counter

Wipe the counter, then the faucet and the drain lip where toothpaste film and hard water scale build up, including the collar at the base of the faucet where a chalky ring hides. Do the mirror last, top to bottom, so drips land on surfaces you have not finished yet.

SAFETY

34 / 96

GUEST BATHROOM

Guest Vanity Counter

Water and electricity: a shaver or hair dryer left plugged in beside a full basin is a live cord within splash reach, so unplug it and put it away rather than coiling it on the counter. Swap any glass tumbler or glass trinket dish for ceramic, because glass on a wet counter slides and it breaks onto a tile floor where feet are ...

STANDARDIZE

35 / 96

GUEST BATHROOM

Guest Vanity Counter

Three things live on this counter permanently: soap, tissues, hand towel. Photograph that exact arrangement and tape the picture inside the vanity door, so anyone in the house can reset the counter without asking you which three.

SUSTAIN

36 / 96

GUEST BATHROOM

Guest Vanity Counter

The moment someone confirms they are coming over, walk in, top up the soap and hang a fresh hand towel, both done before you have put the phone down. The laundry version is smaller: when you put fresh towels away, the guest hand towel swaps in the same motion. Slip is a soap pump below half or a towel that has hung there since ...

SORT 37 / 96

GUEST BATHROOM

Guest Vanity Storage

Pull everything out and be honest about the hotel miniatures: the shampoos from three trips, the lotion nobody opened, the free conditioner samples. Keep the unopened ones a guest would actually use, throw out the started ones, and send household backstock that drifted in here back to the bathroom it came from.

STRAIGHTEN 38 / 96

GUEST BATHROOM

Guest Vanity Storage

Two bins, not five. Guest supplies in one, cleaning products in the other, both light enough to lift out with one hand so the cabinet base stays visible. Toilet paper stacks on its own, where it can be seen the second the door opens, because a guest who is hunting for it will not come and ask.

SHINE 39 / 96

GUEST BATHROOM

Guest Vanity Storage

Empty the cabinet completely and wipe the base, looking for dark rings or softened board that mean the trap has been weeping. Wipe the neck and cap of every bottle, since dried cleaner running down the side is what makes a cabinet sticky.

SAFETY 40 / 96

GUEST BATHROOM

Guest Vanity Storage

Poison, choke, or strangle: bowl cleaner and bleach sitting under this sink are at exactly the height of a visiting toddler who has been sent in to wash their hands alone. Either lift the cleaning bin to a high shelf elsewhere or fit the cabinet with a latch, and never let bleach share a bin with an acid limescale or bowl ...

STANDARDIZE 41 / 96

GUEST BATHROOM

Guest Vanity Storage

Write the two bin labels by hand in plain words a guest can read, Guest Supplies and Cleaning, and draw a line on the shelf at the toilet paper minimum. When the stack falls below the line it goes on the shopping list, no counting required.

SUSTAIN 42 / 96

GUEST BATHROOM

Guest Vanity Storage

When you restock your own bathroom after a shop, open this cabinet on the same trip and build the toilet paper stack back to the drawn line. Two minutes, by whoever shopped. The weekly bowl clean gives the second look, since you are already crouched here, so run a hand across the cabinet base. Slip is a stack below the line, or ...

SORT 43 / 96

GUEST BATHROOM

Shower or Tub

Take out every bottle and turn it over. This is where the household's rejected products retire: the shampoo nobody liked, the body wash that smells wrong, the conditioner welded to the shelf. Keep one shampoo, one conditioner, one body wash, all readable and more than a third full. The rest go, along with the old razor and the ...

STRAIGHTEN 44 / 96

GUEST BATHROOM

Shower or Tub

Hang the caddy or fit a corner shelf so nothing stands directly on the tub floor collecting water underneath it. A bar of soap gets a draining dish, never a puddle. Put a hook inside the door at a height someone can reach with wet hands and no glasses on.

SHINE 45 / 96

GUEST BATHROOM

Shower or Tub

Start with the mold, because it needs time you should not spend standing there: spray the grout lines and the bottom band of the curtain liner, go clean the rest of the room, then come back and rinse. A fabric liner goes in the washing machine rather than getting scrubbed by hand.

SAFETY 46 / 96

GUEST BATHROOM

Shower or Tub

Fall: your guest is stepping into an unfamiliar tub, probably at night, on a surface they cannot judge the grip of. Put a non-slip mat or adhesive strips on the tub floor and make sure there is one thing solidly anchored to grab, because a towel bar screwed into drywall will tear straight out the moment it takes a person's ...

STANDARDIZE 47 / 96

GUEST BATHROOM

Shower or Tub

Three bottles, one soap, one mat, one anchored grab point, and no personal items. If the shower has stood unused for a month, run it hot for a minute before a guest arrives, which clears the stale water sitting in the line and proves the drain is still running freely.

SUSTAIN 48 / 96

GUEST BATHROOM

Shower or Tub

Whoever used it last squeegees the glass or shakes out the liner and drapes the bath mat over the tub rim. Since that person is often a guest who will not know, the host has a second version on departure: whatever they left in the shower comes out with the sheets. Slip is a pink line along the bottom edge of the liner or the ...

SORT 49 / 96

GUEST BATHROOM

Toilet Area

Clear everything from the top of the tank and the floor behind the bowl: the collection of air fresheners, the second brush, the magazines, the box of something nobody has identified in years. One reserve roll stays in the open. Nothing else.

STRAIGHTEN 50 / 96

GUEST BATHROOM

Toilet Area

Put the reserve roll where a seated person can reach it without getting up, since that is the entire point of a reserve roll. Set the brush and the trash can on the side away from the door swing so nobody kicks either one on the way in.

SHINE 51 / 96

GUEST BATHROOM

Toilet Area

Treat the bowl first and let it sit under the rim and at the water line while you work outward: seat hinges, then the base of the pedestal, then the floor behind it, which is where splash and dust collect and where the smell in a guest bathroom actually comes from. Use a cloth in a color you use nowhere else in the house.

SAFETY 52 / 96

GUEST BATHROOM

Toilet Area

Poison, choke, or strangle: a bottle of bowl cleaner parked behind the pedestal sits at a crawling child's eye level, usually with the cap loose. It goes back in the cleaning bin with the cap tight every time. It never shares a shelf with bleach, because bleach and an acid bowl cleaner mixed in a small room with the door shut ...

STANDARDIZE 53 / 96

GUEST BATHROOM

Toilet Area

One visible reserve roll, backstock in the cabinet, brush dry in its holder, liner in the can, no ring at the water line. Write those five lines on a card and stand it in the cleaning bin, so the person holding the brush reads the standard at the moment they are able to meet it.

SUSTAIN 54 / 96

GUEST BATHROOM

Toilet Area

Trash collection night is liner night in here. You are already standing in the room with a bag in your hand, so drop in a new liner and check the reserve roll is upright before you leave. Under a minute. Slip is a can with no liner, or a missing reserve roll, both visible from the door without bending. Recovery is those two ...

SORT 55 / 96

GUEST BATHROOM

Guest Linen Zone

Unfold every towel and look at it in daylight rather than closet light. Anything thin along the fold line, permanently gray, stiff from too much softener, or carrying a hair dye or nosebleed stain comes out of the guest stack. It becomes a rag or a car towel today. It does not go back just in case.

STRAIGHTEN 56 / 96

GUEST BATHROOM

Guest Linen Zone

Store as complete sets rather than in stacks of like with like. Bath towel, hand towel, and washcloth folded into a single bundle so setting up for a visitor is one lift instead of three searches. Two bundles ready covers most households, and the bath mat lives underneath them.

SHINE 57 / 96

GUEST BATHROOM

Guest Linen Zone

Wash the stored set hot even though nobody has used it, because a towel that has sat folded in a closed closet all season carries a musty note that appears the instant it gets wet. Wipe the shelf, then run your hand along the back wall of the closet, since damp there is what the towels have been drinking.

SAFETY 58 / 96

GUEST BATHROOM

Guest Linen Zone

Burn or fire: if this closet also holds the water heater, towels pressed against the tank, a hot pipe, or the heater's cable are a scorch and fire risk that no amount of neat folding fixes. Leave a hand's width of clearance around anything that gets hot, and never let a stack lean on the unit or trap its cable behind it.

STANDARDIZE 59 / 96

GUEST BATHROOM

Guest Linen Zone

Two complete bundles on the marked shelf with the bath mat beneath, and a mark on the shelf edge showing where the second bundle ends. When one is missing, the gap reads as a gap without anyone counting.

SUSTAIN 60 / 96

GUEST BATHROOM

Guest Linen Zone

Departure is the trigger and it covers both rooms at once, so the used bathroom set comes off the rail into the same wash as the sheets. One load, one afternoon. The mark on the shelf edge shows where the second bundle ends, so slip is a gap rather than a count, read with the door open. Recovery is completing the missing bundle ...

SORT 61 / 96

DINING ROOM

Dining Table

Clear the whole table onto the floor in one armful, then sort what came off by owner rather than by type. The homework, the unopened mail, and the half-finished craft project each go back to a person, not back to the table.

STRAIGHTEN 62 / 96

DINING ROOM

Dining Table

Placemats, trivets, and the napkin basket belong in the nearest sideboard drawer, one step from where you set the table. Anything you find yourself carrying in from the kitchen twice a day is sleeping in the wrong drawer.

SHINE 63 / 96

DINING ROOM

Dining Table

Run a fingernail down the leaf seam and the joint where the top meets the pedestal, because that is where crumbs collect and stay. Wipe the chair rungs and the underside lip of the table where hands grip it to pull a chair in.

SAFETY 64 / 96

DINING ROOM

Dining Table

Lift and rock each chair to find a loose rung or a joint that has started working, and turn any chair that moves to face the wall so nobody sits on it before the joint is glued. Keep a trivet in the table's own drawer so a hot dish never lands on bare wood, and keep tall candles well clear of the runner ends.

STANDARDIZE 65 / 96

DINING ROOM

Dining Table

The centerpiece is the table's only permanent resident and its footprint is the boundary. Photograph the table both set and cleared, and tape both pictures inside the sideboard door so the right state is not something anyone has to remember.

SUSTAIN 66 / 96

DINING ROOM

Dining Table

When the plates go to the sink, the homework, the mail and the craft box ride in the same trip, carried by the people who ate. Nothing waits for a second journey, because a second journey does not happen. The test is laying a place: if you have to move something first, the table has stopped being a table. Recovery is giving ...

SORT 67 / 96

DINING ROOM

Buffet or Sideboard Surface

Take everything off the wood, including the picture frames and the candlesticks, and give every piece of paper a verdict tonight: act on it, file it, or recycle it. Burnt-down candle stubs, dried flowers, and chargers belonging to other rooms leave now.

STRAIGHTEN 68 / 96

DINING ROOM

Buffet or Sideboard Surface

Keep the end nearest the table entirely bare for setting dishes down, and group whatever display you keep at the far end near the lamp. Serving spoons and the trivet stack live in the top drawer directly beneath that bare end.

SHINE 69 / 96

DINING ROOM

Buffet or Sideboard Surface

Lift each object rather than dusting around it, then work the wax drips off with a plastic card and gentle warmth, and treat the pale rings left by cold glasses. Dust behind the frames and along the back edge where the wall meets the wood.

SAFETY 70 / 96

DINING ROOM

Buffet or Sideboard Surface

Trace the lamp cord from the shade to the outlet and count everything else sharing that plug, because a sideboard collects a lamp, a charger, and a warming tray on one socket hidden behind heavy furniture nobody pulls out. Move any candle sitting within arm's reach of a curtain or a wall hanging.

STANDARDIZE 71 / 96

DINING ROOM

Buffet or Sideboard Surface

The taped run stays bare, always, and the display group is three objects at most. If you cannot set the roasting pan down without moving something first, the standard has already slipped.

SUSTAIN 72 / 96

DINING ROOM

Buffet or Sideboard Surface

Nothing sleeps on this wood overnight except the lamp and the three display pieces, so the last thing off it each night is whatever arrived that day, removed by whoever set it down. The taped run is the gauge and it reads from across the room: if you could not set a roasting pan on it now, the standard has gone. Recovery is ...

SORT 73 / 96

DINING ROOM

Buffet or Sideboard Storage

Pull every tablecloth, runner, and napkin out and lay them across the table so you can see which sets are actually complete. Partial napkin sets, cloths with stains you have already tried and failed to lift, and serving pieces orphaned from sets you no longer own are finished.

STRAIGHTEN 74 / 96

DINING ROOM

Buffet or Sideboard Storage

Give linens one drawer and serving pieces another, and stand the big platters on edge behind a divider so you stop lifting three to reach the fourth. Roll each cloth with its matching napkins inside it so one pull brings out everything the table needs.

SHINE 75 / 96

DINING ROOM

Buffet or Sideboard Storage

Wipe the shelves and the drawer runners while they are empty, then smell the linens, because a musty note means something went away damp and needs rewashing before it goes back. Check the silver-plate serving pieces for tarnish while you can see all of them at once.

SAFETY 76 / 96

DINING ROOM

Buffet or Sideboard Storage

Heavy stoneware platters and the punch bowl go on the lowest shelf and never above shoulder height, because they come down while your hands are already full. If taper candles and long matches live loose in a low drawer, move them to a latched drawer or a high shelf out of a child's reach.

STANDARDIZE 77 / 96

DINING ROOM

Buffet or Sideboard Storage

Tape a count card inside the door: two cloths, one runner, eight napkins, four serving spoons. A ninth napkin arriving as a gift means an older one becomes a rag that same evening.

SUSTAIN 78 / 96

DINING ROOM

Buffet or Sideboard Storage

A tablecloth out of the dryer goes back rolled with its napkins inside before it touches the back of a chair, done by whoever folds that load. The count card inside the door is a ten second check: four serving spoons on the card and three in the drawer means one is in a cupboard somewhere else. Recovery is finding that one ...

SORT 79 / 96

DINING ROOM

China or Display Cabinet

Take every piece out and split it into three groups: complete sets, chipped or crazed pieces, and lone survivors of sets that are long gone. A chipped rim cannot be mended and is not safe to drink from, so that whole group leaves together.

STRAIGHTEN 80 / 96

DINING ROOM

China or Display Cabinet

Tureens and heavy serving pieces on the bottom shelf, plates and bowls at hand height, ceremonial pieces up top. Stack plates no more than eight high with felt or a paper plate between them, and stand cups single file instead of nesting them into each other.

SHINE 81 / 96

DINING ROOM

China or Display Cabinet

Wash by hand in a plastic basin with a towel in the bottom, never the dishwasher for gilt rims or hand painting, and dry each piece straight away rather than leaving it to drain. Clean the cabinet glass inside and out and wipe the shelf liners while the shelves are bare.

SAFETY 82 / 96

DINING ROOM

China or Display Cabinet

Strap the cabinet to a wall stud, because a tall glass-fronted case loaded with plates is the heaviest tip-over risk in this room and its shelves are the right shape for a child to climb. Do not serve food or drink from decorative antique or hand-painted pieces of unknown origin, since older glazes can carry lead.

STANDARDIZE 83 / 96

DINING ROOM

China or Display Cabinet

Photograph the finished shelves and tape the picture inside the door so the china goes back the same way after every holiday. When a shelf no longer matches its photo, something is missing or broken and you find out that day rather than next Christmas.

SUSTAIN 84 / 96

DINING ROOM

China or Display Cabinet

After any meal that used the good china it is hand-washed, dried and back behind the glass before the kitchen light goes off, which is the host's job rather than the morning's and, for six settings, twenty minutes at the sink. The photo inside the door is the check, so a shelf that no longer matches it means something is ...

SORT 85 / 96

DINING ROOM

Beverage or Coffee Station

Line up every tea box, syrup bottle, and pod sleeve and check the dates, then open the travel mugs and match them to their lids. Anything past date, any mug missing its lid, and the promotional glassware you have never once poured into are out.

STRAIGHTEN 86 / 96

DINING ROOM

Beverage or Coffee Station

Set the station in the order your hands actually move: machine, then grounds or pods, then mugs, then spoons and sugar, then the way out toward the table. Leave a hand's width behind the kettle so its steam is not hitting the underside of a shelf.

SHINE 87 / 96

DINING ROOM

Beverage or Coffee Station

Descale the machine on the interval its manual gives, lift the drip tray grate and wash underneath it where mold starts, and get the sticky ring from under the syrup bottle. Rinse the kettle and look at the element for scale while you are there.

SAFETY 88 / 96

DINING ROOM

Beverage or Coffee Station

Water and electricity share this counter, so give the machine and kettle their own outlet, keep cords back from the edge where a sleeve can hook them, and never refill a plugged-in machine over its own base. If wine or spirits live here, they belong behind a latch or high up, not on an open shelf at a child's eye level.

STANDARDIZE 89 / 96

DINING ROOM

Beverage or Coffee Station

Mugs are capped at daily drinkers plus two, and the bean or pod jar carries a marked fill line that tells you when to buy more. Everything sits on one tray you can lift with one hand, so the counter underneath cleans in a single wipe.

SUSTAIN 90 / 96

DINING ROOM

Beverage or Coffee Station

The reset happens while the coffee is already brewing, by whoever is first up: wipe the tray, top the bean jar to its marked line. Forty seconds inside a wait that was happening anyway. Two signals need no touching, a jar below its line and mugs standing outside the tray because the cap has been passed. Recovery is one wipe and ...

SORT 91 / 96

ENTRYWAY

Coat and Outerwear Zone

Take every coat down. Anything that did not go outdoors once through the last cold season leaves, and so do the single gloves you kept in case the other one turned up. Off-season coats go to a bedroom closet, not to the far end of the same rail.

STRAIGHTEN 92 / 96

ENTRYWAY

Coat and Outerwear Zone

Hooks for what goes on and off daily, hangers only for the wool coat that creases. Set the lowest hook at the height of the shortest person who uses it, and keep the two hooks nearest the door empty for visitors.

SHINE 93 / 96

ENTRYWAY

Coat and Outerwear Zone

Brush the shoulders of the hanging coats, wipe the shelf where dust settles on top of the hat bin, and tip out the umbrella stand. There is always water and grit in the bottom of it.

SAFETY 94 / 96

ENTRYWAY

Coat and Outerwear Zone

Hang your full weight on each hook before you trust it with a soaked winter coat. Hooks driven into plasterboard without an anchor pull out later, with the coat still attached and a lump of wall behind it.

STANDARDIZE 95 / 96

ENTRYWAY

Coat and Outerwear Zone

Write the contents and the season on the shelf bin, hats and gloves, winter, so whoever reaches up for it in October knows without opening the lid whether they have the right bin.

SUSTAIN 96 / 96

ENTRYWAY

Coat and Outerwear Zone

Whoever loads the washing machine walks the rail on the way past, under a minute, returning whatever was left on a chair back or the bannister. The count does the telling: two hooks stay empty, so a full rail read from the doorway means the room is already over. Recovery is carrying the two coats nobody wore this month up to a ...

The standards that keep these zones

GUEST BEDROOM · GUEST BED AND LINENS

Two complete guest sets, each bundled in its own pillowcase and tagged with the bed size, and one of them always on the bed.

> When you carry the departing guest's towels to the machine, the sheets come off the bed and go in with them.

GUEST BEDROOM · GUEST NIGHTSTAND

Lamp, two proven cables, tissues, coaster, wifi card. Nothing of the household's inside the drawer.

> When you make up the bed for an arrival, you switch the lamp on and charge your own phone from both cables before you leave the room.

GUEST BEDROOM · GUEST DRESSER

Top two drawers empty and labeled reserved, lower drawers holding only spare linens for this room's bed, strap fixed to the wall.

> When you swap your own wardrobe over between seasons, you check the guest drawers are still empty before the swap counts as finished.

GUEST BEDROOM · GUEST CLOSET

Six matching empty hangers past the tape line, a clear floor square for a suitcase, and every household bin lidded, labeled and below head height.

> When you fetch or return a seasonal bin, you count the six hangers before you close the door.

GUEST BEDROOM · GUEST WELCOME AND WORK SURFACE

Clear desk, marked suitcase footprint, one labeled welcome bin with the ready-state photo inside the lid, and no cord crossing a walking line.

> When the guest's sheets go into the machine, the welcome bin is restocked and put back before you leave the room.

GUEST BATHROOM · GUEST VANITY COUNTER

The counter holds three things: soap, tissues, hand towel. Anything a visitor brings leaves with them.

> When you put away fresh towels after laundry, swap the guest hand towel in the same motion.

GUEST BATHROOM · GUEST VANITY STORAGE

Two labeled lift-out bins and a visible toilet paper stack. Nothing loose on the cabinet base, so a leak has somewhere obvious to show.

> You already open this cabinet to get the brush for the weekly bowl clean, so run a hand across the base while you are down there.

GUEST BATHROOM · SHOWER OR TUB

One shampoo, one conditioner, one body wash, all readable and above a third full, over a non-slip tub floor.

> When you strip the guest bed after a visit, carry out whatever the guest left in the shower on the same trip to the laundry.

GUEST BATHROOM · TOILET AREA

One reserve roll visible from the seat, a dry brush in a dry holder, a lined can, and no ring at the water line.

> Trash collection night is liner night in here, and the reserve roll gets checked while you are holding the bag.

GUEST BATHROOM · GUEST LINEN ZONE

Two complete bundles, bath towel plus hand towel plus washcloth in each, and the bath mat folded beneath.

> The guest's departure is the trigger: strip the bed and the bathroom together, wash them together, restock the shelf before you sit down.

DINING ROOM · DINING TABLE

Bare wood plus one centerpiece between meals, and every visiting activity arrives in its own container and leaves with it.

> When the plates go to the sink after dinner, everything else on the table travels with them.

DINING ROOM · BUFFET OR SIDEBOARD SURFACE

The taped serving run stays bare, three display objects at the far end, and no paper on the wood at any hour.

> When the day's mail comes through the door, it goes straight past this surface to the chair where you actually open it.

DINING ROOM · BUFFET OR SIDEBOARD STORAGE

A written count card inside the door, linens rolled with their napkins, platters on edge, and the heavy pieces on the bottom shelf.

> When the tablecloth comes out of the dryer, it is rolled and returned before anything else in that load gets folded.

DINING ROOM · CHINA OR DISPLAY CABINET

A shelf photo inside the door, eight plates at most per stack with felt between, the weight on the bottom shelf, and the cabinet strapped to the wall.

> When the last guest leaves, the good china is washed and back behind the glass before anyone turns the kitchen light off.

DINING ROOM · BEVERAGE OR COFFEE STATION

One tray, one outlet, use-order left to right, mugs capped at drinkers plus two, and a fill line on the jar.

> While the morning coffee brews, the tray gets wiped and the jar gets topped back to its line.

ENTRYWAY · COAT AND OUTERWEAR ZONE

Two empty hooks at all times. If there is no empty hook, one coat is in the wrong room.

> On the first morning cold enough that you go looking for gloves, that is the seasonal swap. Do it that morning, standing there, rather than noting it for later.